

>> stretches for everyday life

It's easy to take your stretches into everyday life. Notice how you move when you are grooming yourself, dressing, or even cooking and cleaning, and turn each movement into a stretch. And think “office” as well as “home” to get the most out of your stretch routine.

Look at the ways your body moves in everyday life. Notice how different movements feel, such as brushing your hair or pulling on a sweater or pants. Does the task feel comfortable? Do you have the same range of motion on both sides? How does it feel to bend over to reach to a pet? Let your answers to these questions guide you to set yourself goals that will make an action a little easier or smoother.

Gradual changes

Changes to the way we move happen gradually over time. Diminishing range of motion creeps up on people of every age. A student notices writing arm and shoulders tightening during a long exam. A young mother notices a tight chest or sore lower

back as she holds or reaches down to a toddler. Older adults notice they can't bend to the floor or reach up into pantries as easily as before.

Your adaptable body

Life's distractions, such as being preoccupied with a demanding job, with a new baby, or with having to juggle a long commute with household duties can sideline us from regular physical activity. Then suddenly we notice a change and start to worry that our bodies are not as mobile as they once were.

The good news is that your body is adaptable. It changes to accept what the environment is telling it to do. If you inadvertently restrict its movements—for instance, by sitting for long periods—it adapts to the smaller, less frequent motions. Conversely, it can re-adapt. That's why it's important to find ways in everyday life to get an extra little bit of stretch. Small changes can keep your body healthy over time.

In a crowded schedule

It's commendable to devote an hour or two a day to exercising, but not everyone can do that. Our 15-minute programs make it possible to exercise, even with the most crowded schedule. Yet neither should you overlook the power of taking 25 seconds—four breath cycles—to feel the stretch in an everyday position or movement. This will add to your overall physical well-being. Using this strategy during those overwhelming times of life, when every second appears to be accountable, will pay rich dividends.



Brushing your hair is a great way to stretch the shoulders and chest. Try switching the brush to your non-dominant hand to balance both sides of the body.